Maximiliano Garcia

Economist — Applied Microeconomics — Data Science — Applied Industrial Organization

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Summary

Applied microeconomist with strong expertise in program evaluation, causal inference, large-scale data analysis, markets and institutional design. Extensive experience building and analyzing complex datasets that integrate relational databases, spatial data, and remote sensing to study incentives, enforcement, and resource allocation in real-world environmental markets. Strong programmer with a track record of translating empirical results into decision-relevant insights.

Data, Modeling & Analytical Experience

Large-scale data construction

- Built original research databases integrating SQL-based administrative records, satellite imagery (Landsat, Sentinel), hydrological monitoring data, and GIS shapefiles at basin, farm, and plot levels
- Managed large panel datasets with millions of observations; extensive experience validating and reconciling data across heterogeneous sources

Causal inference & machine learning

- Designed identification strategies using difference-in-differences, event studies, instrumental variables, and RDD
- Applied machine learning methods for prediction, dimensionality reduction, and heterogeneity analysis in high-dimensional settings

Markets and Institutional design, industrial organization & theory-guided empirics

- Used insights from contract theory, industrial organization, and market design to guide empirical specifications
- Modeled strategic behavior under congestion, enforcement frictions, and spatial externalities

Programming & experimentation

- Python, Stata, MATLAB, SQL; GIS tools (ArcGIS, QGIS); Google Earth Engine
- Designed and analyzed field experiments and quasi-experiments
- Produced clear written and visual outputs for policy and non-technical audiences

Education

Ph.D. in Economics — Boston University
M.A. in Political Economy — Boston University
M.A. in Economics — University of Chile
B.A. in Economics — University of Chile

Professional Experience

Postdoctoral Research Associate — 2024–Present
Center for Philosophy, Politics, and Economics, Brown University

- Conduct independent and collaborative research on markets, incentives, and enforcement
- Build and analyze large-scale administrative and spatial datasets
- Present findings to academic, policy, and practitioner audiences

Research Associate — 2015–2018
J-PAL LAC (PUC Chile & Harvard Business School)–Research teams of Dina Pomeranz and Francisco Gallego

- Supported empirical research projects using administrative and survey data, with a focus on applied microeconomics and policy evaluation
- Built and cleaned relational datasets; assisted with data validation, robustness analysis, and replication
- Contributed to empirical modeling decisions and interpretation of results
- Prepared figures, tables, and written materials for academic and policy audiences
- Collaborated with government agencies and NGOs, presenting empirical findings to support policy discussions and decision-making in front of different audiences
- Led and coordinated field survey operations, managing a team of 30 enumerators over a three-month period across two cities

Selected Research

Governing Environmental Markets: Evidence from Irrigation in Water Markets (Job Market Paper)
Studies how institutional design and enforcement affect allocation and investment in resource-constrained markets. Integrates administrative records, satellite imagery, and spatial data to quantify misallocation and equilibrium responses.

Punishing Mayors Who Fail the Test: How Do Voters Respond to Information About Educational Outcomes? (Journal of Development Economics, 2024)
Designed and implemented a large-scale field experiment reaching over 120,000 individuals. Secured approximately $50,000 in competitive research funding and assesed behavioral responses integrating granular spatial data and administrative records.

The Moral Values of "Rugged Individualism". (NBER Working Paper)
Extracts behavioral norms from unconventional big-data sources, including Facebook friendship networks at the ZIP-code level, and shows how norms affect coordination, investment, and responsiveness to incentives.

Do Stronger Institutions Mitigate the Impacts of Climate Change?
Shows how institutional strength reshapes adaptation and distributional outcomes under climate shocks.

Communication & Stakeholder Engagement

- Regularly communicate technical findings to government agencies, NGOs, and non-technical stakeholders
- Experience producing policy briefs, maps, and presentations to support decision-making

Technical Skills

- **Programming:** Python, SQL, Stata, MATLAB
- **Methods:** Causal inference, experiments, machine learning, spatial analysis
- **Languages:** English (Fluent), Spanish (Native), French (Basic)

References

Raymond Fisman
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